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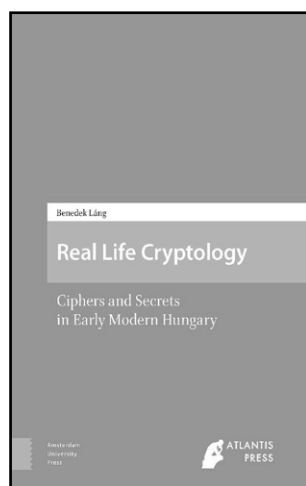
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Benedek Láng,
Real Life Cryptology. Ciphers and Secrets in Early Modern Hungary. Translated from Hungarian by Teodorá Király and Benedek Láng (Amsterdam: Atlantis Press/Amsterdam University Press 2018), 224 pages, ISBN: 978-9462985544, EURO 95,00, eBook EURO 0,00. Originally published as: Titkosírás a kora újkori Magyarországon (Budapest 2015).

Real Life Cryptology sets out to do nothing less than to open a new field of study at the intersection of Cryptology Research and Secrecy Studies concerning the early modern period. It is a valuable contribution to both fields of research concerned and it clearly demonstrates the advantages of an approach combining the study of ciphers with socio-historical analysis of the practices and contexts involved. Apart from that, it is a sound introductory read for historians with no background in cryptology. The subject area of *Real Life Cryptology* are cryptographic ciphers and ciphertexts from early modern Hungary. Láng made a survey of all known archival sources. Thus far, the everyday cryptographic practices of no other region have been covered in this level of detail. The political role as a frontier between East and West made 16th and 17th century Hungary an especially fertile ground for communication using ciphering techniques. Láng's study offers a quantitative analysis of Hungarian ciphers of the 16th and 17th centuries (300 cipher keys as well as 1,600 – sometimes only partly – enciphered letters).

Overall, it can be said that ciphers used in early modern Hungary were mostly monoalphabetic substitution ciphers for which medieval Arabic cryptology had already proposed frequency analysis as an easy solution long ago (of which its users were mostly unaware). Some historic individuals who were more aware of the relative vulnerability of simple substitution ciphers employed additional nomenclatures, that is the substitution of recurring personal names and place names by symbols or code words, for these would offer an easy starting point for codebreakers to target. Especially innovative about the study is the fact that not only diplomatic or military uses of

encipherment are considered, but also a wide range of ciphering techniques of the private life (such as the encryption of shameful diary entries or illegitimate love letters). Láng makes a great effort to uncover the whole process involved in ciphering (not only the decryption key itself, but also less glamorous everyday necessities, like the sharing of the key, secretaries responsible for secret communications, etc.) and aims to explain why many historical actors only used relatively vulnerable and outdated ciphering systems.

This concerns mainly the continued use of monoalphabetic ciphers when polyalphabetic ciphers were already known.

Real Life Cryptology has six big chapters, the rest of the ten chapters are made up of brief interludes, a short summary and the appendices:

1. A literature review ("Uncovered fields in the research literature") combining the thus far disconnected approaches of Secrecy Studies and Cryptology.
2. An introduction on historical ciphering practices in early modern Europe ("Theory and practice of cryptography in early modern Europe").
3. The main part of the analysis, an introduction to the material analyzed ("Ciphers in Hungary: the source material") mostly lists which ciphers Láng found, what system was used and whether the cipher was vulnerable. In doing this, Láng argues that the actual ciphering practice in Hungary was quite far behind from the most recent developments in cryptologic treatises of the time. However, most of the ciphers of the time would be considered quite vulnerable to modern standards. Thus, some of the insights pointed out are quite obvious, as Láng acknowledges himself.
4. A chapter on the social contexts of historical ciphering practices ("Ciphers in action").
5. A chapter reflecting on how historical actors might have learned ciphering practices ("Ways of knowledge transfer"). However, it gives no clear answer apart from the observation that it seems historical actors did not possess the cryptologic literature available at their time or if their libraries had it, they do not seem to have incorporated it into their daily practices.

In the “real life cryptography” investigated by Láng, there is no evidence for an intellectual or scientific interest in the art of ciphering, not even in those well-educated and interested in mathematics. The ciphers in use in the corpus were found to be quite behind the state of the art of the cryptology of their time. Also, a reception of the advanced medieval Arabic tradition of cryptology is found wanting. Another insight is that those using encipherment in their communication do not seem to have gotten their knowledge about it from books. Libraries which could be fully reconstructed sometimes even showed a presence of the authors of famous cryptologic treatises, yet no trace of their works relevant to ciphering.

6. The final chapter (“Scenes of secrecy”) goes into detail mainly with regard to diplomatic ciphering practices, but also mentions uses of ciphers in private communication, like the ciphering of intimate diary entries or love letters (containing details about potentially incriminating matters such as gay love or alcohol abuse). Those private ciphertexts, it seems, in the most part were not meant to be unbreakable but rather to stop those casually peeking at notes which were not intended for them to read.

Frequent repetitions remind the reader that the book’s main aim is to lay out a base for future work: the monograph consists of a rearrangement of disassembled parts of previously published articles by the author which are combined into a larger narrative by supplemented new parts of text. The previously published papers are the following: Benedek Láng, Why don’t we decipher an outdated cipher system?, in: *The Codex of Rohonc*, *Cryptologia* 34 (2010), 115-144. This summarizes the dissertation of the author and includes sections on artificial language. Benedek Láng, People’s secrets: Towards a social history of Early Modern cryptography, in: *The Sixteenth Century Journal* 45, No. 2 (2014), 291-308. Parts of the introduction and literature review, as well as sections on social, private and soldiers’ secrets come from this paper. Benedek Láng, Ciphers in Magic: Techniques of Revelation and Concealment, in: *Magic, Ritual, and Witchcraft* 2 (2015), 125-141. The parts on dissimulation, scenes of secrecy (especially magic, science and alchemy) were published in this article. Benedek Láng, Shame, love and alcohol: Private

ciphers in early modern Hungary, in: *Cryptologia* 39, No. 3 (2015), 276-287. This article deals with the reasons for private enciphering practices. Benedek Láng, Real-Life Cryptography: Enciphering Practice in Early Modern Hungary, in: Katherine Ellison, Susan Kim (eds.), *A Material History of Medieval and Early Modern Ciphers: Cryptography and the History of Literacy* (New York 2017), 223-240. This article is the Ciphers in Action chapter. Here, secretive practices are explored regarding different social strata. Benedek Láng, Shame, Love, and Alcohol: Private Ciphers in Early Modern Hungary, in: *Cryptologia* 39, No. 3 (2015), 276-287. DOI:10.1080/01611194.2014.915270. This article contains parts on private ciphers.

Even though large parts of the book, especially the most diligent case studies, had already been published in journals and the newly added parts are somewhat redundant (chapters 4 and 5), the book represents pioneering work in the historiography of ciphers, combining the socio-historical approach from Secrecy Studies with the field of Cryptology. Since the previously published articles were thoroughly reassembled, *Real Life Cryptology* presents a consistent new narrative. The added chapters make the book more rounded as a monograph on the broader subject of historical ciphering practices; however, it is quite apparent that these new chapters contain fewer references, go less deep and are somewhat redundant. Still, they are useful as introductory material for those new to the topic of Cryptology.

Real Life Cryptology is a very valuable work also in that it gives a literature review on the intersection between Secrecy Studies and Cryptology; the appendix yields both a list of cipher tables and a list of ciphertexts from early modern Hungary. The corpus of material studied is large and representative for the region in question (around 300 cipher keys and other documents were taken into account). It is apparent from the book that the author has studied the field extensively. The book is an extremely useful resource and serves as a very helpful introduction in the study of historical cryptography. The book is important to the field not only in regard to the large body of historical sources it presents and analyses but also methodologically: Láng calls for the more frequent integration of historical cryptologic research in the broader field of Secrecy Studies but also demands that Cryptology research expands more on the social contexts of historical secrecy and ciphering practices.

Spelling errors are not frequent, but noticeable, as well as some translations which do not seem to be idiomatic in English and thus, impede exact grasp of the argument being made. Anyhow, Láng's book is an invaluable first step into the "real life cryptography" of early modern ciphers. Researchers interested in historical Cryptology should ask their institutions to purchase this title. The book format might be

more convenient as introductory reading, but for the relatively high price, one might rather download the book for free as a PDF which is also an available option. *Real Life Cryptology* identifies gaps in previous Secrecy Studies and Cryptology research, their lack of cooperation to date, and presents a first initiative at uniting them.

Reviewed by Sarah Lang



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